Project 2: Narrative Strategy

Ready from Bell to Bell

Cause: Reliable access to free menstrual supplies in North Carolina public schools
Campaign focus: Watauga County Schools
Campaign period: October–November 2026

1. Diagnosing the Dominant Story

A student can walk into a school bathroom and reasonably expect toilet paper, soap, and running water. Nobody asks her to prove she deserves them. Nobody hands her an application.

But if she needs a menstrual pad, the answer may depend on whether she brought one, whether the school has stocked any, and whether she knows which adult to ask.

My campaign begins with that difference.

In 2025, the North Carolina Department of Public Instruction advertised its Feminine Hygiene Products Grant Program on LinkedIn and through an official bulletin. Districts could apply for grants of up to $5,000, awarded on a first-come, first-served basis. Districts that had not previously received money were given preference. In 2025–26, 138 public school units received awards.

That language tells a story. The products are useful enough for the state to help purchase, but their availability is treated as something schools apply for rather than something students can depend on.

The state changed that arrangement in July 2026. Under Session Law 2026-41, the Department of Public Instruction must establish a process for school units to elect to participate in a distribution program supplied through the Diaper Bank of North Carolina, in years when funding is available. This is a meaningful improvement. But the next question is whether the supplies reliably reach the students who need them.

Using the Center for Story-based Strategy's five elements of narrative, I find the following story in the older grant structure and public communications surrounding it.

Conflict. The prevailing administrative story treats access as a resource-allocation problem: schools have limited funds, students have needs, and grants help close the gap. The difficulty is determining how much help schools can afford to provide. What disappears from this account is the cost of having students interrupt their education to solve a predictable problem.

Characters. Administrators and nonprofit providers do most of the acting. They apply for funds, purchase supplies, and distribute donations. Students appear primarily as recipients. Even the state program's name, *Feminine Hygiene Products*, defines the issue through a product category rather than through what students are trying to accomplish: attend school.

Imagery. News coverage often features donated supplies, packed boxes, and volunteer distribution. These photographs show real and valuable work. But they make the donation the event worth photographing, rather than the ordinary Tuesday when a student reaches into a bathroom dispenser and finds what she needs.

Foreshadowing. The older grant story anticipates another application, another funding cycle, and another round of distribution. Its ending is renewed assistance. It does not necessarily envision a school system in which students stop having to think about access at all.

Underlying assumption. Schools are responsible for providing the basic conditions for learning, but menstrual supplies are an individual preparedness problem that institutions may help solve.

That assumption is the point I want to challenge.

I am not claiming that most North Carolinians explicitly believe students should go without supplies. My evidence establishes a recurring story in institutional communications and the structure of assistance, not a statewide public-opinion consensus. Nor does the grant system prove officials are indifferent. In fact, the 2026 law demonstrates the opposite: lawmakers have recognized the need for a more dependable system.

Still, a school can be full of well-meaning people and operate according to an assumption nobody has examined. My campaign asks people to examine this one.

Evidence: NCDPI's 2025 grant announcement; 2026 program report; North Carolina Session Law 2026-41, Section 7.18.

2. The Point of Intervention

The old story breaks when the audience stops asking whether schools should *help* students obtain menstrual supplies and starts asking what a school should keep stocked as part of its normal operations. Assistance is something that may arrive. Readiness is something students should be able to count on.

The 2026 legislation creates an unusually good opening for this change. The state has already recognized the products as a legitimate educational need and established a distribution mechanism. Local schools now have an opportunity to make that policy visible and useful.

My campaign will therefore concentrate on one specific question: **Will Watauga County Schools publicly explain how it is participating in the state program and how students can reliably access supplies?**

I would ask the district to confirm its participation status, explain its distribution and restocking practices, and publish a clear plan for access at middle and high schools.

Before launching, I would contact the district to establish what already exists. If supplies are consistently available, the campaign should document and celebrate that accomplishment rather than manufacture a failure. If availability varies, the campaign should identify the gap and organize around fixing it.

The object is not to make a villain of school administrators. It is to make dependable access an ordinary expectation.

3. Refusing the Inherited Frame

George Lakoff argues in *Don't Think of an Elephant!* that negating a frame can reinforce it. When an audience hears a denial, the original concept has already been activated.

The obvious response to the personal-responsibility frame would be:

"Students shouldn't be blamed for forgetting their period supplies."

But that sentence still makes forgetting the central event. It invites the audience to decide whether the student was careless, whether she should have prepared, and whether someone else should be responsible for rescuing her.

Another possible argument is that periods shouldn't be embarrassing. That is true, but it still makes embarrassment the subject.

I want to talk about something else entirely.

My new frame: A school that is ready for students has what students need to stay in class.

The campaign's name is *Ready from Bell to Bell.*

Its central message is:

Pencils. Soap. Pads. A school day should be ready for all three.

This shifts the conflict from individual preparedness to institutional readiness. It appeals to familiar values: competence, reliability, uninterrupted learning, and the ordinary care adults owe children in their charge.

It also changes the implied protagonist. The student is no longer someone waiting to be rescued. She is someone trying to finish her science lab or take her English test. The school is a capable institution with a practical decision to make.

The comparison to soap is intentional. Nobody considers stocked soap dispensers a remarkable act of charity. They are part of operating a school.

This frame does not resolve every question about funding, appropriate placement, or restocking. Those remain important implementation issues. But it changes the conversation in which those decisions happen.

Instead of beginning with why schools should take on an additional obligation, we begin with what it means to run a school that is prepared for the students attending it.

4. The New Story: Self, Us, Now

Marshall Ganz's public-narrative model moves from a personal choice to a shared choice, to the choice an audience must make today.

The following is a model public narrative written for a fictional college student organizer. In a real campaign, the personal events would need to come from the speaker's actual experience.

Story of Self

In tenth grade, I got my period during second period.

I knew what had happened before I even stood up. I checked my backpack. Nothing. I asked the girl beside me. She didn't have anything either.

By the time I made it to the bathroom, I had already decided I was going to miss part of class. I tied my sweatshirt around my waist and went looking for an adult who might be able to help.

My English teacher opened a desk drawer and handed me a pad. She didn't make a fuss. She just said, "Here you go," and went back to grading papers.

I remember feeling grateful. I also remember wondering why my English teacher had to operate a tiny emergency supply closet out of her desk.

A few weeks later, I asked if I could help keep that drawer stocked. I brought in a box of pads.

It was a small decision, but it changed what I noticed about school. We had systems for sharpened pencils, computer chargers, bandages, and paper towels. Somehow, this other perfectly predictable need depended on knowing which teacher had a drawer.

I started wondering what it would look like if nobody needed to know about the drawer.

Story of Us

My teacher wasn't the only person keeping students supplied.

Across North Carolina, teachers, school nurses, parents, and nonprofits have been doing this work for years. The Diaper Bank of North Carolina has distributed more than three million menstrual supplies to schools since 2014, according to reporting by *North Carolina Health News*.

That number represents an extraordinary amount of organizing. It also shows how persistent the need has been.

In May 2026, student advocates gathered at the North Carolina General Assembly for the Period Power Coalition's advocacy day. They chose to bring the problem to lawmakers instead of treating each missing pad as a private emergency.

That organizing helped build a different expectation about what public schools can provide. The state's new distribution law offers a way to act on that expectation.

Our community now faces its own choice. We can leave this work to individual teachers and charitable supply drives, or we can help make access consistent enough that their emergency stashes become unnecessary.

The people who have already been doing the work should help design the system. Students know where access is needed. Teachers and nurses know what interrupts the school day. Parents know the importance of being able to trust that a school is prepared.

Together, we have the knowledge to ask for something practical.

Story of Now

The state changed its program on July 1, 2026. Schools have a new way to participate in the distribution of free menstrual supplies, subject to available funding.

The opportunity now is to find out what that means in Watauga County classrooms and bathrooms.

Our campaign is asking the Watauga County Board of Education to confirm whether the district is participating, explain where supplies are available, and establish a clear plan for keeping them stocked.

We want that question raised before the board's November meeting cycle. We are not claiming that a vote has been scheduled.

By 5 p.m. on Friday, October 23, will you send one email asking the school board to make that plan public?

It should take less than five minutes. We'll provide the official contact information and a short, suggested message.

A few years ago, I was grateful that one teacher had thought ahead.

I'd like to live in a community where every student can count on the school doing the same.

5. The Audience and the Ask

Chris Rose's values-based audience model distinguishes people partly through what they find reassuring, admirable, or morally important. I will use that principle rather than assume that every parent or educator responds to the same argument.

My first audience is **the practical stewards**: parents, educators, and community members who value orderly schools, careful planning, and responsible use of resources. They want students in class and schools functioning smoothly. They may be skeptical of a campaign that sounds like another unfunded demand.

For them, the message is:

"A five-minute supply problem can become a missed lesson. Let's make sure our schools have a dependable restocking plan."

My second audience is **the community caretakers**: people who value dignity, mutual care, and making sure students can participate fully in school. They believe young people should be able to rely on the institutions serving them.

For them, the message is:

"Every student deserves to walk into a school day knowing the basics are covered. Help us make that promise dependable."

Both groups receive the same request:

Email the Watauga County Board of Education by Friday, October 23, asking it to confirm participation in the state program and publish its supply-access plan.

The differences are in how the request is introduced, not in what people are asked to do.

This is intentionally a small action. I am not asking someone to attend a rally, disclose a private experience, or learn the details of education funding. I am asking them to communicate one clear expectation to decision-makers.

A parent who has never contacted a school board can complete it during a lunch break.

6. How the Story Travels

The campaign will use social media to make a different understanding of school readiness familiar, then move people toward the email action.

The opening Instagram Reel will be thirty seconds long.

It begins with a series of close shots: pencils in a classroom cup, paper towels beside a sink, soap in a dispenser, and an empty shelf where menstrual supplies could be stored. The final shot shows that same shelf stocked.

The narration says:

"Schools prepare for hundreds of things students need every day. Pencils. Soap. Paper towels. Menstrual supplies belong on that list. North Carolina has created a program to help schools provide them. We're asking Watauga County Schools to tell us how students can count on that access. One email. Five minutes. Friday."

The footage will be staged or taken in approved locations, not presented as evidence of conditions at any specific school.

A companion Facebook post will explain the new law in plain language and link to the school board's official contact information. A shareable graphic will carry the central message: "Ready from Bell to Bell."

Instagram will introduce the story through imagery. Facebook will be useful for reaching parents and community organizations. Direct messages and conversations with PTA members and educators will turn passive agreement into relationships.

The posting sequence matters only because each piece has a job. The first introduces the frame. The second explains the opportunity. The third gives people a deadline and an action.

I will not solicit intimate stories from minors or photograph students in bathrooms. Anyone sharing a personal experience must participate voluntarily and understand where the material will appear. Students do not need to reveal personal medical information to support this cause.

After the email deadline, the campaign will share what happened: the number of confirmed actions, any district response, and the next decision. If the district already has a working system, the story should become one of community recognition and accountability rather than accusation.

7. Outcomes and Indicators

A campaign can receive thousands of views without changing anything important.

I want to know whether the story has begun circulating independently of the people who wrote it.

My first indicator is **language**. Before posting, I will collect publicly available district communications and a small sample of local discussion about supplies. I will code how the issue is described: an emergency, a donation, a student problem, or an expected part of school operations. After the campaign, I will collect comparable public texts and look for adoption of the readiness frame. I will preserve screenshots and dates so that I am not simply remembering the language I hoped to hear.

The second is **behavior**. My target is 35 confirmed emails by October 23 and three community members willing to raise the question through the board's public-comment process. Participants can voluntarily report completion without forwarding private correspondence to me.

The third is **relationships**. I want a student representative, a parent representative, and an educator or school health professional to form a small working group that can follow the district's response. I will count that relationship as established only if the members agree to a follow-up meeting or specific shared task without the original campaign organizer directing every exchange.

The most important longer-term indicator is whether the district publishes a clear explanation of participation, access, and restocking. If one already exists, success may mean improving its visibility and checking how reliably it works.

These measures are deliberately different from likes or follower totals. They ask whether people have begun speaking differently, acting differently, and working with one another.

Conclusion

My campaign's aim is not to make menstrual supplies seem extraordinary. It is to make their availability seem ordinary.

That is the story I want a parent, teacher, student, or school board member to carry away: a well-run school prepares for the needs of the students who walk through its doors.

The moment this succeeds, the campaign may become less necessary. Students will stop asking who has an emergency stash. Teachers will stop filling drawers out of their own pockets. A stocked dispenser will be about as interesting as a working soap dispenser.

Which is exactly how it should be.

Completed Story Canvas

Canvas field	Completed campaign plan
1. Story Name	**Ready from Bell to Bell**
2. Purpose	Shift menstrual supplies from an occasional assistance story to an expectation of school readiness. Secure a public Watauga County Schools plan for participation, access, and restocking.
3. Audience	**Practical stewards:** value preparation, efficiency, uninterrupted learning. **Community caretakers:** value reliability, dignity, and looking after students. Both can influence school leaders.
4. Key Messages	(1) A prepared school provides basic supplies. (2) North Carolina has created a distribution mechanism. (3) Reliable access requires a clear local plan.
5. Story	**Hook:** Ordinary school supplies shown alongside menstrual products. **Plot:** One student's interrupted school day becomes a shared question about institutional readiness. **Ending:** Community members ask school leaders to make the access plan public.
6. People & Places	Fictional student narrator for demonstration; actual campaign would use consenting advocates. Parents, educators, school nurses, board members. Classroom, approved bathroom/supply imagery, school-board meeting room.
7. Style & Tone	Practical, warm, direct, hopeful. Natural school imagery; no pity-based visuals. Short vertical video with captions, clear typography, natural sound, accessible graphics.
8. Call to Action	By 5 p.m., October 23, email the Watauga County Board of Education asking it to confirm state-program participation and publish a supply-access and restocking plan. Provide verified official contact information.
9. Campaign	**Oct. 19–20:** Verify existing district practices and gather baseline language. **Oct. 21:** Launch short video and Facebook explainer. **Oct. 22–23:** Personal outreach and email requests. **Late October:** Report participation and district response. **November:** Follow public board proceedings and next steps.
10. Outcomes	Public clarity about district participation and supplies; greater community expectation of consistent access; a small ongoing coalition; a documented next step with the district.
11. Indicators	**Language:** pre/post coding of public statements and posts, with dated screenshots. **Behavior:** target of 35 confirmed emails and three public-comment participants. **Relationships:** three stakeholder representatives agree to a follow-up task. **Institutional response:** publicly available plan or written clarification.

Sources Consulted

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